

SELF INTRODUCTION

What is a Self Introduction?

A self-introduction is a short speech about yourself that you give when you meet new people or start a job. It gives basic details about who you are and your background. The goal of a self-introduction is to provide a quick overview of your personality, interests, skills, education and experience. It allows others to get to know you in a friendly, professional way. A good self-introduction should last 1-2 minutes. It should sound natural, not memorized. The information should be clear, positive and relevant to the situation.

The key parts of a self-introduction include:

- My self Mohamed B Sirajuddeen
- Where you are from
- My job/role or area of study
- Work experience or education/training
- Personal interests or hobbies
- Any other relevant details about yourself

My Self Introduction in English

There are many good ways to start a self-introduction speech in English. Here are some examples:

- "Hello everyone, my name is Julia. It's nice to meet you all."
- "Hi there! I'm Alex Johnson from Seattle."
- "Good morning. I'm Sarah Lim and I'm thrilled to be joining the team."
- "Greetings. I'm Sanjay Gupta and I recently moved here from Delhi."

You can also take a look at some tips to introduce yourself well!

Smiling and making eye contact with the audience is important. Speak slowly and loudly enough to be heard by all.

Some other tips for starting well:

- Have a confident, upright posture.
- Take a deep breath before you start to ease nerves.
- Keep your introduction short - around 30 seconds.
- Sound energetic and friendly.
- Avoid memorizing lines or sounding artificial.

The opening sets the tone for your whole introduction. A warm, genuine start will make you feel more relaxed and engage your listeners right away.

Tips for Introducing Yourself in English

When introducing yourself in English, it's important to strike the right balance between clarity, confidence, and authenticity. Here are some essential tips to help you make a great impression.

1. Keep It Relevant

Focus your introduction on details the interviewers would find most relevant. Tailor it based on the role and company.

For example, for a teaching job highlight your education, experience with students and teaching skills. For a sales job, feature your sales achievements, customer service skills and product knowledge.

2. Structure Your Content

Organize your content in a clear, logical structure:

- Name and where from
- Education/degree and school
- Work experience and achievements
- Skills and strengths
- Interest or hobby
- Why interested in the job/company

This flow makes your background easy to follow. Adjust details based on relevance.

3. Emphasize Skills

Carefully choose which of your skills, strengths and achievements to highlight based on the target job.

For example, creative skills for design roles, analytical abilities for accounting, collaboration for team-oriented jobs, and so on. Give specific examples of using those skills successfully.

5. Keep Within 2 Minutes

Interview introductions should be kept short - ideally 1-2 minutes max.

Provide a concise overview of your most relevant credentials. Elaborating can come later during the actual interview.

6. Practice Aloud

Practice introducing yourself out loud several times before the interview. Get feedback from friends.

This boosts your delivery and reduces nervousness. Practice until the flow sounds natural.

7. Show Enthusiasm

Sounding genuinely excited about the company and job opportunity creates a very positive impression.

For example, "I'm truly excited about the chance to join ABC Company's innovative marketing team."

8. Listen to Cues

If the interviewers jump in with questions part way through your introduction, take the cue to wrap up quickly. Don't keep talking extensively.

Aim to give concise responses from that point to best answer their questions.

9. Close on a Positive Note

End your introduction by expressing enthusiasm for the job interview and your interest in the position.

For example, "I'm looking forward to discussing how I can contribute to this role." This finishes well.

Following these tips will make your self-introduction highly effective and help get the interview off to a great start!

What to be Included in Self Introduction for Interview

Your interview self-introduction should touch on these key elements:

1. Full Name and Where From

Start by clearly stating your full name and where you are originally from or currently living.

For example, "My name is Nitin Reddy and I'm from Hyderabad."

2. Education and Qualifications

Briefly summarize your academic background and credentials relevant to the job.

For example, "I hold a Bachelor's degree in Commerce from DU College of Business. I'm also a qualified Chartered Accountant."

3. Work Experience

Highlight work roles and companies you've been part of that relate most to the position. Focus on achievements.

For example, "I have over 5 years experience in corporate banking. At XYZ Bank I streamlined loan approval processes which increased customer acquisitions by 15%."

4. Skills and Strengths

Mention 2-3 top skills you possess that match the job requirements and would make you excel in the role.

For example for sales roles: "My key strengths are developing rapport with customers and crafting persuasive presentations."

5. Interest/Hobby

Sharing one soft skill/personal interest creates a well-rounded picture of yourself.

For example, "In my spare time, I enjoy playing cricket and volunteering at animal shelters."

6. Motivation/Interest

Close your self-introduction by expressing genuine excitement about the company and role.

For example, "I'm greatly looking forward to being part of this dynamic team and supporting the company's rapid growth."

Verbal Communication

Verbal communication is perhaps the most obvious and understood mode of communication, and it is certainly a powerful tool in your communication toolbox. Put simply, verbal communication is the sharing of information between two individuals using words.

Examples of verbal communication skills include thinking before one speaks, knowing your audience, being precise and concise, being prepared to clarify in a friendly manner, and speaking clearly.

Non Verbal Communication:

Nonverbal communication is a process of sending information without the use of words. Understanding how verbal and nonverbal communication work is important to ensure the correct message is transmitted.

Non-verbal communication examples

When we interact with another person, we are constantly giving and receiving non-verbal cues. The kinds of verbal and non-verbal signals we give or receive present themselves in many forms.

Facial expressions

Your facial expressions can intensify, diminish, or can cover up the emotions that you are feeling. Many facial expressions, such as curving your lips in a smile or furrowing your brows in frustration, are seen as universal forms of non-verbal communication. These facial expressions are perceived in the same way by many different cultures. For example, when we smile, the people around us tend to interpret our expression as happiness.

Gestures

Every gesture adds to how effectively you share your emotions and adds emphasis to spoken words. For example, large hand and arm movements create greater emphasis while smaller gestures can communicate something more specific, like holding up two fingers to indicate the

number two. Another example of a gesture is head movements. Simply nodding or shaking your head indicating 'yes' or 'no' without ever saying a word.

Knowing gestures and what they communicate can be helpful when giving instructions or directions, especially when you are traveling and there is a limited understanding of the spoken words.

Body Language

Another main form of non-verbal communication, our body language can reveal our inner thoughts and messages to others. Our body language consists of body movement and posture. How we move or carry ourselves can substitute a verbal message.

However, the same body language can be interpreted differently by listeners. For instance, when you cross your arms, you can seem defensive or disinterested. Similarly, playing with your fingers may indicate anxiety or boredom.

Paralinguistics

The tone of voice, rate, volume of speech, and stress placed on words (collectively known as paralinguistics) are a few more examples of non-verbal cues. Paralinguistics can complement and add to the verbal message, as well as accentuate a verbal message by emphasizing parts of the message. However, these cues are not universal as it depends on the urgency of the message, the emotions of the speaker, which language is spoken, and cultural and regional influences.

What is the difference between verbal and non Verbal Communication?

Verbal communication is using speech or spoken word to exchange information, emotions, and thoughts. Conversely, non-verbal communication is conveying and exchanging messages without the use of spoken words.

Though silent, non-verbal cues can convey our feelings, attitudes, and actions to other people more effectively than speaking. Research has shown that about 80% of how we converse involves non-verbal communication, while only 20% involves verbal communication.

EXTEMPORE

Extempore refers to speaking or performing something spontaneously, without preparation or rehearsal. In an extempore speech or presentation, a person is given a topic and is expected to discuss it immediately, relying on their existing knowledge and improvisational skills rather than a prewritten script. Extempore speaking is common in settings like debates, interviews, or public speaking exercises, and it tests a person's ability to think quickly, organize thoughts coherently, and communicate effectively under time constraints.

What is the purpose of extempore?

Because of their spontaneous nature and the ability to test the thought process of candidates, top schools and companies are increasingly embracing extempore as a vital element of their selection process.

This enables the administration to evaluate and test the candidates on the following –

- Presence of mind
- Thought process
- Ability to communicate
- Presentation of ideas in a fast-paced, high-pressure environment
- Speaking style
- Good content and accuracy of thoughts

What is the role of extempore in admissions and hiring

Extempore speaking is the term used for a non-formally prepared speech.

Extempore assesses a person's ability to think on their feet, knowledge of a wide range of topics, and presentation skills. It is a key component of the personal interview round since it allows the interviewer to understand the interviewee's personality and ability to handle a crisis. Knowing the process helps you prepare effectively for the round. The procedure for the extempore round during MBA admissions is outlined here.

- The interviewer assigns a topic to each candidate. Since the topics cover many issues, being well-prepared is essential.
- Following that, the candidate is allowed 15-30 seconds to think about the issue and organize their thoughts to present it. They must give a speech that lasts between one and two minutes.
- The candidate is free to interpret the issue as they see fit and explain their ideas clearly. The secret is to merge one's imagination and understanding of the subject to offer intriguing and interesting information.

Skills you need

Extempores do not always assess an individual's knowledge of the subject. It assesses a person's reasoning abilities, communication skills, and self-confidence. The person who nails

an extempore round is the one who gets through to the audience. It is critical to understand the abilities needed to succeed in the extempore.

Some of the skills that you can develop to perform well in the extempore round are listed below

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- Ability to communicate
- Body language that is composed and poised
- Thinking logically
- Confidence
- Ability to Analyse
- Possessing the ability to think on your feet

How to succeed in extempore

A few fundamental strategies can be used to succeed in an extempore performance. Following are some ideas to remember to speak effectively in your forthcoming extempore round.

- **Time Management** – This can be difficult because the time allotted in an extempore is quite limited, and one must present all of the points quickly. Preparing beforehand with a timer can help you manage your time more effectively.
- **Think First** – It is critical to think about and contemplate the topic. The impact of a speech can be harmed by rambling without a structure or any essential points. Before putting your best foot forward, outline and organize your thoughts.
- **Maintaining a calm demeanor** – Maintaining a calm demeanor and powerful body language makes you appear more assertive. Hyperactivity during conversation can lead to muttering or blunders, reducing the impact of the communication.
- **Tone** – Be audible while maintaining a pleasant and inviting tone. It aids in communicating with the audience, making your arguments valued and given more weight.
- **Conclusion** – It is good to end an extempore positively to achieve greater results. The panelists pay more attention to the conclusion and benefit from the issue, praising the speaker's reasoning ability and positivism.

Here's an example of an extempore response for the topic: "The Importance of Technology Education."

*"Good [morning/afternoon], today I'd like to discuss the importance of technology education in our modern world. In a society increasingly driven by technology, having a solid understanding of tech skills is essential for students and professionals alike. Technology education equips people with critical skills like coding, data analysis, and digital literacy, which are now highly valued in nearly every industry. Beyond just job preparation, it fosters problem-

solving abilities and creativity, as technology often requires innovative thinking to develop new solutions.

Furthermore, technology education promotes adaptability, preparing students to navigate and succeed in a fast-evolving digital landscape. By understanding technology, individuals become more capable of making informed decisions, whether related to privacy, online safety, or how best to use digital tools. Ultimately, technology education is not just about learning specific skills; it's about empowering people to thrive in a world where technology plays an ever-growing role."*

Self-confidence

Self-confidence is important for success as it provides you with the belief in your skills to overcome different kinds of challenges. Developing confidence often requires ongoing reflection and practice. By taking the steps to improve self-confidence, you may also feel more comfortable facilitating meetings, networking, interviewing and performing in a leadership role. In this article, we explain what is self-confidence, why it is important and what characteristics a self-confident person has.

What is self-confidence?

The answer to the question, "What is self-confidence?" is that it is a quality that promotes and strengthens your belief in your own abilities. Self-confidence enables individuals to develop faith in their competencies and to trust their own judgments, decisions and skills. High levels of self-confidence can motivate professionals to complete challenging tasks and address complex problems. Self-confident individuals may be able to reflect upon their strengths and weaknesses and assess situations objectively to contribute solutions to problems.

Self-confidence differs from self-esteem although they are similar concepts. Self-esteem refers to an individual's ability to value themselves. Self-confidence refers to an individual's faith in their own capabilities, especially in the context of a task or challenge. For example, individuals with high self-esteem may still experience a lack of self-confidence while performing a task they are not familiar with.

Why is self-confidence important in the workplace?

There are several reasons self-confidence can benefit a professional in the workplace. When you are confident, you may be more open to taking calculated risks that may contribute to professional success. Self-confidence can also arise from having a comprehensive understanding of one's own abilities and weaknesses. This understanding is crucial for professional growth as it empowers individuals to process feedback and criticism in a healthy manner.

Self-confidence can also help you share your ideas and express yourself with freedom. It is a quality that has the potential to facilitate creativity and innovation in a professional context. In addition to these aspects, self-confident people are also a positive influence on colleagues and other individuals around them.

Characteristics of a self-confident person

A self-confident person typically depicts the following characteristics:

Believes in themselves

Confident people often take part in and contribute to group discussions. They present their thoughts and opinions confidently as they have faith in their judgement, skills and approach to professional tasks. Self-confidence also helps professionals become more decisive and assertive while making important organisational decisions.

Voices their opinions

A key characteristic of confident people is that they follow through in action, with what they believe is right. As a self-assured person, you might be open to taking feedback from peers before making your final decision. Self-confident people may also put forward their views in a composed manner. This quality gives individuals the ability to believe in their ability to make correct decisions and use their aptitude to persuade others.

Takes on new challenges

Having trust in your abilities may enable you to seek challenges to test and garner experience and knowledge. A self-confident person usually believes that they can successfully overcome difficulties they face, by applying relevant skills, knowledge or experience. Taking risks and achieving targets can further increase levels of self-confidence in individuals.

Accepts criticism positively

Success and failure are both possible in professional and personal life. A self-confident person may illustrate the capacity to accept both praise and criticism politely and constructively. They may be more inclined to listen to feedback and use it to overcome challenges.

How to be more confident in the workplace

These are 10 steps that you can follow to be more confident in the workplace:

1. Identify your weaknesses

Start by identifying and listing your weaknesses. Distinguish between the ones that are critical to your performance and the ones that are not. Go through past achievements and performance evaluations to understand how you have grown professionally over the years. This can help increase confidence. Speak to colleagues and team members to identify which aspects of your work you can improve upon. It can also be helpful to list a few of the most recent achievements to generate motivation to develop further.

2. Draft a plan to address weaknesses

Once you identify weaknesses, it is important to create a realistic plan to overcome them. You may consider taking suggestions from professionals who have addressed similar weaknesses in the past. If required, speak to an expert to learn more about how you can compensate for certain weaknesses that impede productivity. Counsellors and mentors can give you suggestions to excel professionally while considering your mental health needs, job satisfaction levels and work-life balance.

3. Prepare for meetings and group discussions

Presenting your views before a large group can sometimes be challenging, especially if you feel that you lack public speaking experience. Whether you are speaking during a group discussion or presenting during a team meeting, preparation enables you to become familiar with your key talking points. This reduces chances of faltering mid-speech and digressing into irrelevant topics and also prepares you for answering follow-up questions after the meeting or discussion.

4. Try new things

While it may be easy to remain within a comfort zone, challenging yourself by taking on new projects in the workplace or even outside it can help you gain new skills and improve self-confidence. For example, you can lead a new initiative, sign up for an online course or develop a new hobby outside of work. New endeavours also expand your knowledge base and aid networking by helping you connect with a wide range of professionals.

5. Participate in performance evaluations

Most companies have performance evaluation systems to assess the performance and productivity of their employees at regular intervals. During performance evaluation sessions, you can ask managers relevant questions to better understand your strengths and weaknesses from a third person's perspective. A self-assured person typically takes steps to improve themselves after receiving feedback. This also indicates to an employer that you give due importance to performance evaluation processes and constructive feedback.

6. Enhance your unique abilities

Review portfolios of professionals working in similar domains to understand how good you are in terms of expertise, experience and skills. Identify areas or domains where your performance has a competitive edge over that of your peers. Systematically focus on developing and expanding these unique competencies to improve your employability.

7. Set realistic expectations and goals

Achieving goals and meeting expectations can help build confidence. Once you set your goals, create a process that details how you can achieve them. Do not forget to measure your progress throughout the process. Set SMART goals, which are specific, measurable, achievable, realistic and timely. The SMART goal framework provides a structure using which you can set and achieve goals systematically.

8. Believe in yourself

Negative thoughts and criticism can lead to self-doubt. Engage in self-reflection periodically to process critical feedback and negative emotions. Try to understand how an inspirational figure like a family member, acquaintance, supervisor or mentor might respond to similar circumstances. You can also read motivational books or listen to speeches of inspirational individuals to grow as a professional.

9. Build a professional network

Fostering good relations with colleagues can also help build confidence. You can offer to help a teammate with their project or have a recreational engagement with a colleague outside of work. This helps to build a strong network of professionals who can help you when you require assistance with professional tasks. For example, you can ask a colleague or friend for help by rehearsing a presentation or report with them. If you are not comfortable practising with someone, you may videotape your presentation or stand before a mirror to analyse it yourself. If you have written material to present, you can seek the help of a colleague to gauge its readability and the quality of your articulation.

10. Care for your physical and mental health

Maintaining your physical and mental health, both within and outside of the workplace is key to being self-confident. It is difficult to feel self-assured unless you feel fit and energetic on a routine basis. Consider following a healthy diet and exercise routine to maintain health and fitness. You may also adopt precautionary measures to alleviate stress related to excessive screen usage.

LEADERSHIP QUALITIES

Leadership qualities encompass a range of traits and skills that enable someone to guide, inspire, and support others toward a common goal. Here are some key qualities that define an effective leader:

1. ***Vision***: A good leader has a clear sense of purpose and vision, helping others understand the direction and inspire them to reach shared goals.
2. ***Integrity***: Trustworthiness and honesty build credibility. Integrity ensures that leaders act consistently with their values and principles, which earns respect from others.
3. ***Communication Skills***: Effective leaders communicate clearly, listen actively, and provide constructive feedback. They keep everyone informed and motivated.
4. ***Empathy***: Understanding and sharing the feelings of others fosters a supportive environment, showing that the leader genuinely cares about their team's well-being.
5. ***Adaptability***: In dynamic situations, leaders must be able to adjust strategies, remain calm under pressure, and guide their team through challenges.
6. ***Accountability***: A strong leader takes responsibility for their actions and decisions, holding themselves and their team accountable for outcomes.
7. ***Inspiring and Motivating***: Leaders should encourage others to perform at their best, often leading by example to motivate their team through enthusiasm and a positive outlook.
8. ***Confidence***: Confidence inspires trust. A leader who believes in their abilities and decisions instills confidence in their team.
9. ***Decisiveness***: Good leaders can make decisions promptly and effectively, even in uncertain situations. This prevents delays and maintains team momentum.
10. ***Delegation***: Effective leaders recognize others' strengths and delegate tasks accordingly, which empowers team members and fosters growth.

11. ***Problem-Solving Skills***: Leaders often need to solve complex issues creatively and efficiently, finding solutions that benefit everyone involved.

Developing these qualities over time can help anyone become a more capable and respected leader, able to create positive impact and inspire others.

Leadership qualities to be place in software companies

Developing leadership qualities that align with what software companies value can greatly enhance your chances of landing a job after college. Here are the most relevant leadership qualities to cultivate:

1. ***Technical Proficiency and Continuous Learning***: Demonstrating a solid understanding of programming languages, tools, and frameworks is foundational. Embracing continuous learning and staying updated with industry trends shows your commitment to growth.

2. ***Problem-Solving and Analytical Skills***: Software companies value leaders who can break down complex problems and find efficient, logical solutions. Practice these skills by working on coding challenges and participating in hackathons.

3. ***Effective Communication***: Strong written and verbal communication skills help you explain technical ideas to non-technical stakeholders and collaborate effectively with team members.

4. ***Adaptability and Agility***: The tech world is dynamic, with new technologies and tools constantly emerging. Being adaptable, quick to learn, and comfortable with change makes you a valuable asset.

5. ***Team Collaboration and Emotional Intelligence***: Software development often involves working in teams. Developing emotional intelligence to understand team dynamics, resolve conflicts, and collaborate effectively is essential.

6. ***Project Management***: Handling multiple responsibilities is common in tech jobs. Practicing project management skills, like organizing tasks, setting goals, and meeting deadlines, is crucial.

7. ***Attention to Detail***: Bugs and errors can cause big issues in software. Cultivating a meticulous approach to reviewing code, testing, and quality assurance demonstrates thoroughness and responsibility.

8. ***Initiative and Proactivity***: Taking the lead on projects, offering ideas for improvement, and seeking out new learning opportunities show initiative and a proactive attitude, which are highly regarded in software roles.

9. ***Customer-Centric Thinking***: Software companies prioritize the end-user experience. Practicing empathy and thinking from the user's perspective helps in developing applications that are both functional and user-friendly.

10. ***Time Management and Organization***: Tech jobs often involve tight deadlines and multiple projects. Strong time management skills will help you balance responsibilities and improve productivity.

11. ***Mentoring and Knowledge Sharing***: Mentoring peers and sharing your knowledge can demonstrate leadership potential, as software companies value individuals who can contribute to a learning culture.

12. ***Curiosity and Innovation***: Employers in software fields look for people who can think creatively and drive innovation. Experiment with side projects and be curious about emerging technologies to showcase your passion for tech.

13. ***Resilience and Perseverance***: Projects can face setbacks and challenges. Being resilient, learning from mistakes, and maintaining a positive outlook helps create a problem-solving mindset that companies value.

Developing these qualities will prepare you not only to get a job in a software company but also to succeed and grow as a leader in a tech-driven environment.

SWOT ANALYSIS

What Is SWOT Analysis?

SWOT (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats) analysis is a framework used to evaluate a company's competitive position and to develop strategic planning. SWOT analysis assesses internal and external factors, as well as current and future potential. A SWOT analysis is designed to facilitate a realistic, fact-based, data-driven look at the strengths and weaknesses of an organization, initiatives, or within its industry..

How to Do a SWOT Analysis

A SWOT analysis can be broken into several steps with actionable items before and after analyzing the four components. In general, a SWOT analysis will involve the following steps.

Step 1: Determine Your Objective

A SWOT analysis can be broad, though more value will likely be generated if the analysis is pointed directly at an objective. For example, the objective of a SWOT analysis may focused only on whether or not to perform a new product rollout. With an objective in mind, a company will have guidance on what they hope to achieve at the end of the process. In this example, the SWOT analysis should help determine whether or not the product should be introduced.

Step 2: Gather Resources

Every SWOT analysis will vary, and a company may need different data sets to support pulling together different SWOT analysis tables. A company should begin by understanding what information it has access to, what data limitations it faces, and how reliable its external data sources are.

In addition to data, a company should understand the right combination of personnel to have involved in the analysis. Some staff may be more connected with external forces, while various staff within the manufacturing or sales departments may have a better grasp of what is going on internally. Having a broad set of perspectives is also more likely to yield diverse, value-adding contributions.

Step 3: Compile Ideas

For each of the four components of the SWOT analysis, the group of people assigned to performing the analysis should begin listing ideas within each category. Examples of questions to ask or consider for each group are in the table below.

Internal Factors

What occurs within the company serves as a great source of information for the strengths and weaknesses categories of the SWOT analysis. Examples of internal factors include financial and human resources, tangible and intangible (brand name) assets, and operational efficiencies.

Potential questions to list internal factors are:

(Strength) What are we doing well?

(Strength) What is our strongest asset?

(Weakness) What are our detractors?

(Weakness) What are our lowest-performing product lines?

External Factors

What happens outside of the company is equally as important to the success of a company as internal factors. External influences, such as monetary policies, market changes, and access to suppliers, are categories to pull from to create a list of opportunities and weaknesses.

Potential questions to list external factors are:

(Opportunity) What trends are evident in the marketplace?

(Opportunity) What demographics are we not targeting?

(Threat) How many competitors exist, and what is their market share?

(Threat) Are there new regulations that potentially could harm our operations or products?

Companies may consider performing this step as a "white-boarding" or "sticky note" session. The idea is there is no right or wrong answer; all participants should be encouraged to share whatever thoughts they have. These ideas can later be discarded; in the meantime, the goal should be to come up with as many items as possible to invoke creativity and inspiration in others.

Step 4: Refine Findings

With the list of ideas within each category, it is now time to clean-up the ideas. By refining the thoughts that everyone had, a company can focus on only the best ideas or largest risks to the company. This stage may require substantial debate among analysis participants, including bringing in upper management to help rank priorities.

Step 5: Develop the Strategy

Armed with the ranked list of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats, it is time to convert the SWOT analysis into a strategic plan. Members of the analysis team take the bulleted list of items within each category and create a synthesized plan that provides guidance on the original objective.

For example, the company debating whether to release a new product may have identified that it is the market leader for its existing product and there is the opportunity to expand to new markets. However, increased material costs, strained distribution lines, the need for additional staff, and unpredictable product demand may outweigh the strengths and opportunities. The analysis team develops the strategy to revisit the decision in six months in hopes of costs declining and market demand becoming more transparent.

Benefits of SWOT Analysis

A SWOT analysis won't solve every major question a company has. However, there's a number of benefits to a SWOT analysis that make strategic decision-making easier.

- **A SWOT analysis makes complex problems more manageable.** There may be an overwhelming amount of data to analyze and relevant points to consider when making a complex decision. In general, a SWOT analysis that has been prepared by paring down all ideas and ranking bullets by importance will aggregate a large, potentially overwhelming problem into a more digestible report.
- **A SWOT analysis requires external considerations.** Too often, a company may be tempted to only consider internal factors when making decisions. However, there are often items out of the company's control that may influence the outcome of a business decision. A SWOT analysis covers both the internal factors a company can manage and the external factors that may be more difficult to control.
- **A SWOT analysis can be applied to almost every business question.** The analysis can relate to an organization, team, or individual. It can also analyze a full product line, changes to brand, geographical expansion, or an acquisition. The SWOT analysis is a versatile tool that has many applications.
- **A SWOT analysis leverages different data sources.** A company will likely use internal information for strengths and weaknesses. The company will also need to gather external information relating to broad markets, competitors, or macroeconomic forces for opportunities and threats. Instead of relying on a single, potentially biased source, a good SWOT analysis compiles various angles.
- **A SWOT analysis may not be overly costly to prepare.** Some SWOT reports do not need to be overly technical; therefore, many different staff members can contribute to its preparation without training or external consulting.

TELEPHONE ETIQUETTE

Phone calls were once the be-all and end-all when it came to remote communication in the business world. Once upon a time, when salespeople weren't at meetings, they'd spend all day on the phone.

But as communication mediums have diversified – from email, Skype and virtual calls to texting and social media – is the humble phone call still important?

According to recent research, the answer is yes. In 2019, the length of calls to businesses increased by 22%, and the number of calls from consumers in the purchase phase of the buying cycle is increasing.

But as we talk on the phone less in our personal lives – with many people favoring text or messaging services – phone etiquette runs the risk of slipping, especially among younger employees.

With this in mind, here are our top telephone etiquette tips that are still very much needed for success in 2024.

1. Answer Quickly

Customers want to know you care about them, and leaving the phone ringing conveys a lack of urgency. It may even cause prospects to believe that customer service isn't a priority at your organization.

59% of customers prefer to call because they want a quick answer. If you fail to deliver that, you may end up losing a sale.

Picking up the phone after ring number three is a good rule of thumb – you don't want to pick up after one and startle your caller. And you don't want to be flustered and start the call on the back foot, either.

2. Introduce Yourself

In this era of social media, it can be easy to assume that business contacts have checked you out on LinkedIn and already have some idea of who you are. But the rules are different over the phone.

Unless you've spoken to a prospect before, take the time to explain who you are, what your role is within the organization, and how exactly you can help them and vice versa.

If this is a relationship you want to build, you can always follow up the call with an email including your digital contact details.

3. Set out the Purpose of the Call Early on

Every single call should have a goal, and in order to meet that goal, both parties need to be on the same page from the start.

There's no awkwardness in stating the point of the call early on – as long as it's done right. Be clear and concise, but friendly. Professionals are more time-poor now than ever before. They'll thank you for providing this direction.

4. Speak Clearly

This might sound obvious, but we're not as used to speaking on the phone as we used to be.

When your voice is your only mode of communication – without facial expressions or body language – it's vital that you speak clearly and at an appropriate volume. While this can take a little bit of effort, mumbling will betray a lack of knowledge or confidence.

Remember, no one can lip read on a voice call. Make an effort to practice speaking on the phone to ensure you come across the way you intend to.

5. Master Brand Tone of Voice

We know that tone-of-voice branding your marketing team has been pushing on you? When the phone rings, it's time to use it. The most successful brands these days have a cohesive tone of voice across all platforms – including on external calls.

If someone calls up a brand that presents itself as friendly and caring only to be met with a cold response, it will be jarring. Similarly, if the caller expects a professional, corporate tone, and discovers an overly casual voice on the other end of the phone, the brand will feel less authentic.

Look at your organization's tone-of-voice document and work out – with the help of the marketing team – what you can do during phone calls to ensure you're upholding it. This could be the language you use, the content of the call, or simply how formal or informal you are. Most likely, it will be a mix of all three.

6. Give Your Full Attention

Just because you're hidden behind a phone doesn't mean you can slack off. They might not be able to see you, but the person you're speaking to will know if your attention isn't fully on them.

Asking questions and taking notes – and letting them know you're writing down what they say – will help to make them aware that they're receiving the level of attention they deserve. Repeat some of the details of what they say back to them to prove you're listening – this sales trick is as old as time, but it works.

7. Ask Before Putting Someone on Hold or Transferring

This is a simple courtesy that's all too often overlooked. Asking the person on the other end of the phone before you transfer them or put them on hold will go a long way to easing their user journey with you.

Simply pressing the button with no warning will come across as rude, and – with no timeline in mind – the caller may simply hang up. Think about how you like to be treated on a phone call, and extend the same courtesy to your callers.

8. Stay Positive

Perhaps the trickiest one on the list, staying positive is vital for those representing their company over the phone, even when dealing with complaints.

If you feel you can't handle a complaint or difficult customer, stay positive and tell the caller you'll get back to them as soon as possible. This buys you time to collaborate with colleagues on how best to move forward.

9. Remain Polite

As the old saying goes: "Manners cost nothing."

Regardless of your brand tone of voice or the situation on the phone, there's absolutely no excuse for deviating from being polite. Staying respectful and professional, even in trying situations, will go a long way toward gaining the mutual respect required to achieve the goals of your call.

10. Don't Be Afraid to Switch Mediums

Look, the reality is that it's 2024 and many people hate speaking on the phone.

In some workplace situations, speaking on the phone is completely unavoidable. But when trying to build a strong relationship with a new contact, consider asking them for their medium of choice.

Being the one salesperson or account manager who is willing to switch from using a virtual phone number for business to communicating with them via Skype or text, for example, will help you win major points with the phone-phobic among us.

DEBATE

Goals & Objectives

The primary goal of a debate is for students to generate effective critical thinking into primary issues in the given topic. Sample objective statements include:

Through active participation in the debate activity, students will...

- compare and discriminate between ideas x and y,
- verify the value of evidence for concept x or y,
- resolve controversies,
- recognize strengths and weaknesses of arguments,

...as determined by successfully attending to at least 80% of the rubric items for the assignment.

Prerequisites

Students need an adequate reading level as well as enough background or time to develop background knowledge into the concepts being explored to develop effective debate tactics and topics.

Materials and Resources

What needs to be prepared in advance by the teacher? – The instructor should have questions prepared to help guide the debate.

What does the student need to bring to the lesson? – The time and ability to carefully read and analyze the given topics.

Guiding Questions for this Activity

How well can the students prepare and present logical argumentation for topic x or y?

How well can the students discriminate the pros and cons of the concepts x and y?

Activity Outline and Procedure

- First decide if this will be a formal or an informal debate. The formal debate would have more guidelines and clear topics. Informal debates can include exploration of issues where neither side actually takes a side or cases where everyone agrees but some are assigned devil's advocate roles.
- Once decided, the instructor can provide rules for the debate or they can be chosen by class consensus.
- Students can be provided the topic and then find their own resources, or the instructor can provide a listing of resources pertinent to the topic. They will usually coincide with readings for that unit of materials.

- The actual debate can be synchronous with a required time limit or asynchronous with a requirement to actively post during the debate time (2-3 days). With an asynchronous debate, multiple debates would occur simultaneously.
- During the debate, questions are usually addressed to the debaters with an alternation between who answers first and second. These may coincide with or follow an initial address stating their position.
- Each participant should be given a final statement.
- Following the debate, the instructor can provide feedback on performance. Peer review can also be used.
- Participants in the debate can also write a self-improvement synthesis.

Teaching Strategies

- Guest can be used to facilitate the debate or even provide an expert on one side or both.
- The debate may also be joined with the fishbowl activity to provide additional assignment options.
- Many controversial topics can lead to students with strong feelings one way or another. An environment should be maintained whereby students are respectful of one another. You can also suggest that students argue a topic counter to their personal views so as to address the issues from new viewpoints.
- Encourage non-debaters participation by accepting questions from them.

Accommodations

What accommodations may be needed for students with disabilities or other special needs? These will depend on the nature of the debate. For example, a synchronous debate using a text-based communication tool would require additional time for dyslexic students or those using accommodations for physical disabilities.

Timeline

Anywhere from 10 minutes synchronously to 5 days asynchronously could be provided for the students to develop a background knowledge of the topic and prepare statements and strategies. A follow-up time of 10 minutes synchronously or 2 days asynchronously may be used for additional comments.

Ideas for Activity Evaluation and Teacher Reflection

How did the students like the lesson? End of semester evaluations should ask about the usefulness and learning accomplished through such activities. Both knowledge and performance including such items as congeniality can be measured. Participants in the debate can also write a self-improvement synthesis.

How was student learning verified? An assessment should be performed on the quality of both the initial response by students, and any counter responses. Furthermore, retention of the knowledge should be tested by students ability to build on this knowledge with later units. Peer

assessment during the debate can also be performed. The designing online debate site in the additional readings section below includes assessment ideas as well.

Group Discussion

Group discussion (GD) is a comprehensive technique to judge the suitability of an individual and his appropriateness for admission, scholarship, job, etc. GD assesses the overall personality – thoughts, feelings and behaviour - of an individual in a group. A topic is presented to the group members for discussion. While the discussion is going on, a group of panellists observe them. Through this observation they judge intellectual, social, leadership, communicative skills of candidates taking part in the GD.

Importance of GD

For admission to some of the universities, B- Schools, campus placements after graduation or for recruitment to a multinational company, you need to have knowledge of the field and also have the capability to work in a group as a leader or as a member. The group discussion technique is a very effective way to judge the candidate's ability to work in a group.

What are the skills that are judged in a GD?

- How good you are at communicating with other
- How easily you behave and interact with the other group members
- How open minded you are
- How flexible or rigid you are in accepting the view- points of others in the group
- Your leadership skills
- Your analytical abilities
- Problem solving & critical thinking skills
- Time management skills
- Your skills at putting forth your ideas in an unbiased manner
- Social attitude and confidence

A Preview of a Group Discussion session

A group was given a topic for Group Discussion – ‘Education is the only way to remove poverty’. One of the candidates in the group, ‘Vishal’, was very aggressive in his manner of putting up the arguments in favour of the topic. Many times he even cut down other candidates and barely allowed others to speak. He spoke rudely in case anyone put up a different view and his voice was also loud. His body language was rude and not pleasant. He was doing this to appear like a leader who knew the most about the topic of discussion.

Do's of participating in a GD

- Think before you speak.
- Pick up clues from the discussion and intelligently add points that come to your mind with regards to the topic, in case you don't know much about the topic.
- Back up your points with facts and figures if needed.

- Be gentle and sure in your presentation of views.
- Speak to-the-point and make sure that you do not repeat the points.
- Be calm and composed while speaking.
- Listening to others is also an important aspect of participation in the group discussion, so listen to others.
- Have respectful attitude towards the viewpoints of others.
- Your body language should convey your ease of behaviour.
- Sometimes the discussion may take a hostile turn. In such a case it is a good idea to intervene to make the situation relaxed. This act of yours will show your leadership and problem solving skills.

Don'ts of participating in a GD

- Do not initiate the discussion if you do not know the topic well.
- Do not go overboard in exhibiting your knowledge even if you know the topic well.
- Do not interrupt other members when they are speaking.
- Do not change your opinion about the topic just because most of the other participants are having an opinion different from yours.
- Do not feel unconfident if a speaker prior to you has presented the points more effectively than you.
- Do not ask irrelevant questions.
- Do not let your personal biases about the topic enter the discussion

Points to be kept in mind before the GD

No one knows what the topic of GD is going to be. Hence, it will be a good idea to keep yourself abreast with topics like:

1. Current Affairs

Current Affairs is something that you have to be thorough with. For this, read newspapers regularly and watch news on the television. Understand the recent crises that the world is reeling under, the latest developmental initiatives, the ties between various countries and the like.

2. Historical topics

Have a fair knowledge about the country's history and also the history of other countries. The topics may not be specifically from this area, but having historical information will help you cite examples and make references whenever needed.

3. Sports, Arts & Literature

4. Data crunching

Familiarize yourself with important data. Throwing in some data if required in your GD will definitely create an impression among the assessors.

Read as much as possible. Have good and sound knowledge on numerous topics. Watching documentaries on various topics will help here. Improve your vocabulary. This does not mean that you use heavy and big words, but it means that you will be able to understand the topic better and contribute effectively.

Verbal Reasoning Tests

According to the job role, verbal reasoning tests are used by some recruiters to find out the potential of a candidate and their learning capabilities from their past work experiences. These may be less complicated in some cases, but may also increase in difficulty depending on the management level of the job you have applied for. In a less complicated verbal reasoning test, you may be asked to complete various sentences and analogies that employees commonly use in a work environment.

On the other hand, the complex ones may include reading and comprehending a piece of text or information provided, thinking about the information on logical grounds, drawing conclusions accurately, and finally conveying the results to others in an understandable yet professional manner. These are some common activities generally expected of the employees working in a business organization that need to be done in an effective and professional manner.

Below are some basic attributes that recruiters may evaluate in candidates through appointing a verbal reasoning test. Moreover, they may put as much significance on this one as they usually do in numerical reasoning tests.

- My ability to pin-point issues from business manuals and company reports, and logically come up with conclusions as to how these may be taken care of or eliminated.
- My ability to work on business reports, collateral and documents that are easily understandable at all levels.
- My ability to convey and articulate any problems in the organization or its processes in order to bring it to the concerned committee.
- My ability to decide how positively an issue may be resolved or the possible solutions at hand.

Finally, both numerical reasoning and verbal reasoning tests may provide some useful insights into your professional competency to determine the likelihood of hiring you for the vacant job position you have applied for. Candidates who are not competent enough to take up a certain post may fail in these tests and lose their opportunity to appear for the interview, which is usually followed by these tests. To express yourself as the perfect candidate and to make the recruiter think that you are genuinely determined to get this job role, your test answers should show the amount of time you have spent in preparing for it. A poor score may ruin this impression that you are trying to create on your prospective employer.

Many organizations include these tests as part of their recruitment process because in today's data-driven marketplace, the business strategies, products development, and future business directions are all determined by the correct analysis and assessment of the trends and patterns we see globally. An employee who has a hands-on knowledge of this seems to be an asset to the organization. Thus, candidates who pass in these exams and appear in the subsequent interviews are found to be more competitive, adaptable, and intellectual, and fit for the jobs they have applied for.

Numerical Reasoning Tests

A numerical reasoning test will help provide recruiters an understanding of your ability to analyze and interpret various questions usually given in the form of tables, graphs and data.

The employers need to ensure that you are able to draw reasonable and logical results out of the provided data for a certain job role. A numerical reasoning test may give them an insight into the attention to details that you may give in any given situation. These tests may not help them assess your mathematical knowledge; however, these will help evaluate how logically you will reach to a decision and how knowledgeable and well-versed you are.

You should know how numerical reasoning test scores help the recruiters decide on the most competent candidate from many, for a certain job role. In a professional work environment, crucial decisions are usually made based on the data, figures and trends of the previous years. These decisions may include monitoring the progress of a business strategy, analyzing results driven from a business strategy, or elements that may have helped the business in achieving previous business goals. Thus, there are several interpretations and analyses that will need to be effectively done as a part of the job role to make better and informed future business decisions. These test scores will give recruiters an idea about how the candidates will comprehend these critical aspects of the business and whether or not they may add any value to the company in achieving their business goals.

Thus, some employers may use your scores of the numerical reasoning test you have participated in to analyze the following factors:

- My ability to identify issues related to business processes to make a critical analysis.
- My ability to draw logical conclusions and present logical alternatives to the processes.
- My ability to implement those presented solutions.
- My ability to monitor business results and progress by going through data and figures, and to make analysis of the graphs.
- My ability to further communicate and convey issues and their solutions with the help of graphs and tables.
- My ability to think critically.
- My ability to perform and communicate estimates.
- My speed of making correct analyses and evaluations.
- My amount of concentration in assessment and problem solving.

In a data-driven business environment, it is essential for the existing and potential employees to have strong numerical reasoning skills without which any kind of professional job may become challenging. Generally, below kinds of questions are given to the candidates to test their numerical thinking and reasoning skills:

- Interpretation of tables
- Arithmetic
- Manipulation of data
- Interpretation of graphs

- Interpretation of patterns

However, the above ones usually consist high level of skill assessment questions that are beyond the basic level of addition, multiplications, subtractions, divisions and the likes. The key is to make predictions with the use of data while accurately comprehending each value regardless of how they may be presented.